Participative Intimacy in/as Design for Coexistence

Affective Prefiguration Politics and Collaborative Futures

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Abstract

In a year when our community asks "How can participatory design facilitate coexistence?", we respond by discussing an intimacy born of working collaboratively, examining the political aspects of the affective charge of trying other ways of being. The paper builds on the interest of participatory design (PD) in the nuance of co-creation to offer two concepts: *Affective prefiguration* to describe creating interpersonal states ahead of a world in which they are commonly experienced. *Participative intimacy* is one such type of state, relevant to PD, when people find meaning in meeting and creating together. Using these terms enables us to notice – and thus promote – the particular collaborative opportunities for working with imagination and reflection that design brings to our future-making. The paper ends with suggestions for how we might deliberately create the conditions for intimacy to develop.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → Participatory design**.

Keywords

Futuring, Intimacy, Politics, Coexistence, Affective Prefiguration

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1 Introduction

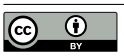
How can participatory design facilitate care-filled coexistence? Light [38] calls the process of encountering not just new feelings, but ways of feeling, affective prefiguration to draw attention to the possibility of invoking anticipatory practices of feeling and challenge current catastrophe narratives (e.g.[43]). Here, we look at one form of this with the idea of participative intimacy. Although we accept that neither experience, in general, nor intimacy, in particular, can be created by design, we discuss what is meant by these terms as a provocation for others to think with. Our context for this is collaboration in designing as a means to explore possible future ways of being, allowing us to bring aspects of these worlds into being. The rest of the paper describes a background of affective work in participatory design (PD), the inception of the terms and their potential use. Before continuing, we note the authors are based in Europe and write from a position and privilege where it is possible to research and plan without wholesale interference from weather, global politics or the state.

2 Background: Relations in PD

Marking a move to analyse PD in specifically relational terms, Light and Akama wrote about 'structuring future social relations' in 2014 [39]. But PD has always been concerned with relations between beings as well as the tools or systems that may be the focus or outcome of research. Early PD in workplaces addressed the politics of managers and employees alongside computerisation [54]. More recently, human-world relations have become a bigger focus, with, for instance, ReWorlding [32] and The Tree as Method [47], sensitisation to pluriversality [16] and more-than-human [31].

Alongside this, there has been a turn to on-the-ground relations: capacitating communities, infrastructuring [33], institutioning [55] and other forms of sociotechnical and cultural change-making that meet PD's ambitions for collective opportunity to work inclusively for betterment. Democratic design experiments [11] produced socio-political outcomes, as has PD futures research (e.g.[22]). Kuenen advocates for an 'aesthetic of futuring' in design to point to 'open-ended futures' ([34]:231) and Neuhoff and colleagues' [44] systematic review calls for more public futuring for social learning: i.e. one branch of PD has concerned itself with how we relate, reflecting well-established principles to support people 'in conceiving and enhancing their own life collaboratively' [19].

Further, PD concerns itself with emotional wellbeing. However, emotion is not a key focus [5], more an assumed input, outcome or byproduct of designing. For instance, when Wang et al [58] mention older adults identifying 'positive social experience' in working intergenerationally, they comment on it looking sideways in a hackathon process for designing material interventions. We see applied literature on care (e.g.[39],[48],[61],[3],[45]), power (e.g.[50],[14],[49],[62]) and trust (e.g.[64],[37]) rather than theoretical engagement with the production of emotional and affective experience. Notable exceptions are few but significant: Ehret and



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Hollett [23] develop concepts of placemaking and belonging as affective dimensions essential to generating and sustaining change; Frauenberger et al [26] ask how PD 'can put forward democratic visions of technological futures that connect to people's hearts' and Yee et al [63] describe intense – often hidden - emotional and affective labour involved in collaborative mentoring. There are texts discussing types of affect, such as Lindström et al [41] on hope and grief in climate futures; and, addressing researchers' feelings, Christensen and Ahsan [17] on guilt and shame in doing PD. PD research is full of reaction: disagreements, betrayals, anger, hope and value choices: there is no shortage of feeling. It is rather that it is rarely the point; designing as a practice generally concerns itself with material stressors to be eliminated.

One factor influencing (the absence of) affective focus in PD may be an understanding of affective elements as individual in a domain that addresses the collective, noting that qualities such as care, power, and trust exist in a relation of 'being between', i.e. intersubjective qualities. English poorly describes between-ness: Akama introduced the Japanese term 'ma' [2] for what exists in that allegedly-empty between space, while Luhmann talks of 'trust in trust' [42], suggesting people have developed perceptions of what lies there. Cozza's team [19] point to engineered atmosphere: 'an emergence that lies beyond the human subject and involves the environment in ways that the human cannot always control'. Stewart speaks of affect regarding fleeting and changeable aspects of existence relating to the complex personal and social dynamics of the political world [53]. Thus, distinctions between affect as personally and collectively felt and/or generated vary and are culturally produced. Here, delving into general affect theory is out of scope; instead, we consider the relational in how we might:

- collectively anticipating and creating future affective states;
- describe and foster positive experiences of work on futures.

3 Affective Prefiguration

Affective prefiguration [38] talks about relatings that do not (much) exist in the present but can be hinted at or sampled through the design of encounter. It refers to a glimpse of how relations could feel, acting as a spur to investigate inaccessible forms of relationality that we might wish for in (post)industrial societies (and which might be present in others). 'To effect urgent change, we require different capacities for feeling as well as different feelings. Affective prefiguration means giving experience in the present of what else might be emotionally and relationally possible' (ibid.). Light has argued that adding this extra dimension might invoke a constitutive anthropology [35]: using PD futures work as 'staged encounters' to align people in new relations and learn what is possible for them when conditions support a changed way of being (ibid.): what humans together could become and be. As Brandt and Foverskov comment on living labs: 'co-designing should not be about single situations being mocked-up, but about their interrelated connections and how contextualised and relational practices are materialized and co-produced' [12].

This chimes with broader definitions of prefiguration, such as Fians' [25], describing prefigurative politics as: 'strategies and practices employed by political activists to build alternative futures in the present and to effect political change by not reproducing the social structures' they oppose (np); social movements enacting the change they want to see. In PD, prefiguration enters through work by DiSalvo [20], Asad [4] and Gerber and Hegel [28], concerned with different ways of organising. This stresses progressive structures - new economies, different legal systems, replacements for policing - designed to contrast with the mainstream and feed into social practice [46] as applied vision of different infrastructure.

Prefigurative practices, as political, are all about relations. Yet, how people experience each other in forming and being part of prefiguration is commonly seen as adjunct to the material processes of building a better system. An exception is Volpi and colleagues [57], who call for 'ludic prefiguration': rekindling the radical political roots of participatory process by leveraging the power of play to test out alternatives, embracing cooperative playfulness to actualise democratic visions.

Affective prefiguration builds on this to point to the emotional texture of prefigured collective life. This gives primacy to evolving relations rather than the structures that might emerge in/through designing. Scrutinising these aspects of engagement (and labelling them) draws attention to under-researched dimensions of cultural change – articulating something hardly visible and easy to overlook if approached with a focus on infrastructure, governance and the politics of distribution - the more normal foci of prefigurative initiatives. Instead, we propose a politics of relating.

This points to the invisible work that takes place in forming and working to bring about change or offer alternatives. It speaks, like Star and Anselm [52] or Yee et al [63], to a form of invisible care work. It differs from pure facilitation in its ambitions, finding an extra resonance in bringing a session into being that can reveal something new. A different relationality is served by articulating and manifesting the changed human-world relations one wants, including with non-human species. If encounters can be staged to create different worlds (with different values), through being able to feel (and help others feel) differently, this allows us to learn our potential as humans by stretching reality to reveal it.

4 Intimacy and Participation

We focus here on affective forms emerging as people (and other beings) come together. Affective prefiguration can reflect terror on hearing about fires, floods, famine, structural violence and other instabilities, in which case it becomes a 'wake-up call'– providing a vision of horrors that have not yet afflicted all. But this has not worked to motivate deep-rooted change. Instead, here, we explore a more actively hopeful mode [43], with the potential to capacitate rather than frighten and debilitate.

Relations of togetherness are hard to articulate. Efforts have been made to capture the experience of togetherness particular to performing together. There is work on synchronisation in making performance, such as on how musicians improvise together [15] – a particular kind of 'betweenness'. We note Bassetti talks of 'being together in there' [6], describing collaborative performance and the feeling coming with collective production of coordinated activity. We view this collaborative production through the proposed concept of participative intimacy ([36][40]).

Participative intimacy draws on the work of cultural theorist Berlant, who explores intimacy detached from sexuality and other

forms of tight coupling [9]. Berlant proposes that intimacy could emerge from 'much more mobile processes of attachment'. She goes on: 'it is a kind of wild thing that is not necessarily organised that way, or any way. It can be portable, unattached to a concrete space: a drive that creates spaces around it through practices. . . . Intimacy seen in this spreading way does generate an aesthetic, an aesthetic of attachment, but no inevitable forms or feelings are attached to it.' ([9]284-5). This 'aesthetic of attachment' relates to what emerges from collaborative production - a form of affective encounter familiar to those in the PD community.

Intimacy is a visceral sense of attachment before valence, judgment, or the like; it is sensory rather than emotional feeling. Drawing on Berlant's insights, intimacy here refers to a coming-together to experience moments of power that stay as connections between people, forged as shared encounters in a temporary space drawing on mobile processes of attachment. It is an attempt to supply the English language and impoverished cultures of technocracy with the means to draw attention to particular relational feelings, noting these qualities might have a more sustained presence in other cultures, such as South American *Buen Vivir* (e.g.[1]), Filipino *Kapwa* [30] and *Ubuntu* in parts of Africa ([10],[24]). The questions are a) what fosters these attachments in impoverished cultures and b) what concerns are raised in doing so.

4.1 Feeling(s) and Politics of Attachment

We argue that positive ways of relating are critical to development of agency. Nonetheless, promoting intimacy may look devoid of politics or guilty of emptying it out - and PD values justice and inclusion. Sociologist Giddens proposes a link between intimacy and democracy, such that 'self-disclosure [. . . involves] a relationship of equals, where each party has equal rights and obligations' and 'each person has respect, and wants the best, for the other' resisting 'arbitrary power, coercion or violence' [29]. This suggests what participative intimacy might offer: in agreeing to participate, people are thrown into a negotiation of coexistence without hierarchy, believing others operate in good faith and will co-construct a generous experience together with benign goals. Intimacy, here, speaks to the values of conviviality as a form of between-ness, rather than protections. But it requires an absence of feelings of oppression to emerge, which, in turn, speaks of good facilitation in group spaces.

Within these encounters, there is always more nuance. We do not suppose all attachment is positive in feeling or intent. We do not consider negative feelings necessarily a negative outcome. We do not expect feelings to be experienced similarly across regions and cultures or even between two people working together in the same place or between human and other species. We do not dismiss structural inequalities or their impacts in the moment, being mindful of global histories of colonialism and local imbalances of power. Yet the aesthetic of attachment, as experienced as intimacy, promises to be a quality that emerges from mutual regard and is often shared and welcomed between parties, offering affective alternatives-in-the-making.

Affect, Stewart argues [53], is registered in its particularities, connecting people and creating common experiences that shape public feeling. We propose that certain attachments promote hopeful actions, solidarity and care as common experiences. They relate to a sense that aspects of the world are worth working for. Bennett [7] suggests: 'one must be enamored with existence [. . .] to be capable of donating some of one's scarce mortal resources to the service of others' (p4). These relations – of being enamoured, of donating to others – are both forms of closeness and what Bennett calls, elsewhere, vibrancy [8]. This affective charge can help in choosing where to place one's efforts; it can lead to care, caring and further participation.

This brings to mind Durkheim's 'collective effervescence' [21] and Collins' 'emotional energy' [18]: positive feelings they see as motivating in choosing to repeatedly attend (religious) gatherings, form rituals and, ultimately, create institutions. While much PD is not ritual(lised), there is something in the connections made, attachments felt and sense of achievement that speaks to this mood. The idea of affective prefiguration carries suggestion that people who have experienced a strongly positive relation might want to build the conditions to repeat it. But we heed Wiesse's [59] critique of Collins and Durkheim for 'implied utilitarianism in maximising "emotional profit" and "emotional entrainment"' (p2). Wiesse proposes a more mediated account: that affectivity is incorporated 'into the dynamics of meaning-making and vice versa' (p5). This places agency with participation, closer to what is proposed here.

5 Applications and Limitations

We have discussed participative intimacy as a coming-together to share an encounter to create that may hold, within it, seeds of transformation. We argue this is affective prefiguration, not just as an output of making, but as part of the process of becoming through collaboration. We offer this as resourcing: providing terminology and analysis to help designers/researchers articulate components of their practice. Each addition to our vocabularies helps construct our discipline(s) and we suggest that discussion and adoption of these new terms could help with the invisible aspects of making practice.

Willis suggests we make our designs, but they also make us [60]. Frauenberger and colleagues [26] ask how PD can create futures people might seek to live if given space to imagine them. Here we point to the potential to simultaneously make the futures we seek - that the two do not exist separately and that the act of seeking inclusive and caring futures is a prefigurative step towards worlds that better serve the needs of all living beings.

What we take from intimacy, which makes it particular to the work we describe, is the frisson in these encounters arising between participants. This frisson becomes visible in the practices of a group where intimacy unfolds through presence, gesture and shared creation. At *ArtsCentre*, young adults with lived experience of seeking asylum or migration meet weekly. Through applied theatre practice, attendees are invited to imagine and rehearse inclusive futures grounded in collective agency. With English language secondary, connection grows through shared rhythms: meals, check-ins, greetings and games. Over nine months, researchers witness a process of collaborative creation, as the group uses moodboards, alter-egos and storytelling to design and perform a fashion show. During one session, a participant uses his design - half-suit, half-dress - to speak about how clothing can mask the complexities of who we are. How easily people mistake appearance for truth, overlooking

the deeper experiences and emotions that lie beneath the surface. He alludes to assumptions made about him during his four-year migration across several countries. To emphasise his point, he pulls at the clothes he is wearing and then taps his head and chest. Others fall still, listening intently; those nearby offer quiet gestures of recognition - a nod, a murmur, a gentle touch. Through shared acts of identity-making, the group performs a collective politics of care. Participative intimacy here signals more than emotion; it is a sustained, relational practice of reconfiguring belonging.

In participative designerly tasks, relations produced go beyond cordial; they are changed together by a) coming together, and b) coming together to create, sometimes over months and years [40]: learning 'about collaborators' knowledges, intentions, and commitments, becoming part of an ecology of practices out of fragments …itself transformative' and finding 'common pursuits and growing respect; to feel an affective bond even as we theorize differently about relations' (ibid). People create ephemeral new structures, with no institutional bearings or preconceptions about how to make sense of the encounter, yet offering a precious inter-subjective quality, i.e. that lives between, like care, trust and power do. This can act as a platform for other, more articulated qualities, such as emotions and actions.

5.1 How to Spot Participative Intimacy?

'How might one provide evidence of intimacy, especially when it is one of the least describable experiences in human life?' ([51]:23). We offer analysis to draw attention to tacit qualities. It is not necessary to be aware of them to benefit from them. And we do not need to be purist about intimacy to work with it, yet it is worth considering characteristics.

We can point to a suite of relations, from empathy to care to belonging, in which intimacy can be generated and supported and to which it can, in turn, contribute. It is intersubjective affect at its simplest. While empathy may be one-sided and may overstate what is really understood between beings, intimacy flourishes in the 'in-between' and must be mutual. While care may be projected (care about) or given (care for), it has imbalances [56]. Intimacy, as an aspiration, is a 'relationship of equals' [29], in which something else can be born. This 'aesthetic of attachment' [9] distinguishes it from other feelings, making it special in prefigurative terms. As noted, it is a visceral sense of attachment before valence; sensory rather than emotional. It is a fabric upon which futures can be woven. Linked to the hope that manifests in collaboratively designing futures, it becomes a strong base for neighbourhoods and other communities of interest to build on.

5.2 Managing the Politics

Structural politics do not go away merely because a pair or group was able briefly to enjoy connection. However, being able to interact without oppression, as good facilitation can enable, allows difference to be appreciated, acknowledged and may be a basis for trust [37]. When using games as method, 'power relations and other factors that might hamper idea generation are downplayed' [13]. If playful processes of connection downplay factors that hamper ideas creation, what then is the place for conflict and other important agonistic processes in intimate situations? The prefigurative politics of which we speak may be about making the change we want to see, but not everyone will agree on what should emerge.

Intimacy makes space for the negotiation of opinions and needs, for listening and demonstration of support lacking in many other (increasingly polarised) forums. It can be potent when reflexivity is sufficient to go beyond a feeling to acknowledgment of these changed relations and what they offer. Drawing attention to such moments and their capacitating can be another mark of good facilitation. Beyond the active hope this may enable [43], the sense of togetherness and belonging are features lacking from much thinking about futures, from scare stories of environmental calamity to the individualism promoted by neoliberal politics.

Yet, first, there is no guarantee that people will leave with a sense of togetherness. It can be designed for, but it cannot be designed in. The agency remains with all participants. If relations go beyond cordial - charged and changed by coming together to create - there is potential for a shared, even enhanced, sense of agency as an outcome, but this is not a given. Second, even when successful, this achievement is not without its concerns: it would not be healthy if a sense of intimacy permanently obscured present inequalities or built faith in authoritarianism. Participative intimacy, like the 'effervescence' of which Durkheim speaks [21], can build movements of all kinds. Participative intimacy as a form of affective prefiguration carries the suggestion that people who have experienced it might want to build the conditions to repeat it. We note the dangers of this, while reflecting on the barriers.

5.3 What can Designers Do?

So, last, we move from observing the workings of participatory intimacy to creating the conditions for it, in the context of:

- collectively anticipating and creating future affective states;
- describing/fostering experience of creative work on futures.

Participants engaged in working collaboratively towards better coexistence - as organisers or members of communities - can create the right conditions to support the growth of intimacy. Volpi and colleagues [57] advocate rekindling political roots by leveraging play to envision and test alternatives. Work on alternatives may involve play, but it is more than play: it is care, with organisers and participants building relations as part of intense, hidden labour. There is more than method that goes into making moments that can be safe, inspiring, collaborative and connecting. In summary, there are specifics we can attend to in aspiring to participative intimacies by:

- Prioritising process over output;
- Noticing conditions, not just outcomes;
- Scaffolding emotional safety;
- Recognising the designer as care worker;
- Supporting identity formation and agency, across generations and difference, opportunity and loss;
- Offering responsiveness, rather than seeking to control;
- Seeing design as political, not neutral
- Identifying and acknowledging changes in affective state.

Perhaps most importantly, if we want to use these moments in acts of care and community-building, the collective practicing of reflexivity cannot be overestimated: noting as researchers, creators

and participants when an intimate moment has meaning for us and noting the difference that makes for us and for others.

6 Conclusion

We have drawn on concepts of *affective prefiguration* and *participative intimacy* to explore the benefits of organising people to find new meaning and new relations. Co-designing futures, the loose descriptor we have used to assemble these collective design practices towards coexistence, does not have a tangible outcome. We might argue that, apart from the trajectory while the group works together, there is nothing to specify. *Making Futures* [22] describes 'bottom-up formations of collaborative services and creative communities' (p4) with 'no single future arriving first and fastest, only multiple, heterogeneous, and controversial futures that are in the making, composed through the networking, the many entanglements' (p10). There is also no straightforward travel guide.

Intimacy offers a new lens to understand this journey. Building participant agency through small personal interactions is necessary before demanding greater political participation, argue Gautam and Tatar [27], where a value of PD lies 'in the process itself if it helps participants position themselves as actors in the larger world.' We can identify the importance of the local and specific even in great existential and global matters. Intimacy, like care, cannot scale: it loses the significant connection brought by mutual recognition and subsequent affective change; it is always grounded in what is safe enough, attractive and meaningful in place. In situating ourselves in the smaller details of life together, with an agenda to build the collectives that can act locally and in concert with others, we address the question as to how PD might facilitate living together - in a recursive acknowledgment that by living closely and kindly and planning to build on that basis, we may be already making that change. We suggest this can prefigure the emotional texture of a collective life. This can happen in the everyday but may be worked for more deliberately [35]: aligning people in new relations to learn what is possible for them to become in the right conditions. If intimacy is a practice, it manifests in rhythms of connection and micro-political interventions that affirm belonging. Viewed this way, we are free of any instrumentalism, of participative intimacy as a tool, and can practice it as a form of love.

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